recounted (at some length) that his own father Maulana Siraj-i Minhaj was subject to Baha' al-Din's repeated entreaties to leave Firuzkuh and join the Bamiyan court.[57] Maulana finally acquiesced – in fact, "*without* the permission of Sultan Ghiyath al-Din" – for which Baha' al-Din rewarded him with two *madrasa*s "[having] grants (of land) and plentiful benefactions."[58]

All the more surprising, then, is the apparent paucity in traces of newly constructed twelfth-century architecture in the Bamiyan region. Juzjani made note of amply endowed *madrasa*s during the reign of Sultan Baha' al-Din – though without the embellishments of his description of Firuzkuh's Baz Kushk-i Sultan. Moreover, parallel to what we saw at Firuzkuh, circumstantial evidence supports the assumption that the Bamiyan rulers – at the very least Baha' al-Din – would have patronized civic and religious architecture, and also palatial complexes (cf. below). But few remains can be dated *exclusively* to the late twelfth century. Of course, we must bear in mind that subsequent intervention in a landscape like Bamiyan – more heavily traversed than Ghur – would cause substantial changes in and erasures of historical traces over almost a millennium. The Mongol retribution visited upon Bamiyan (1221–1222 CE) alone could have done much of the job, given the Chinggisids' extraction of disproportionate penalties from locales simply resisting their onslaught, not to mention the extermination of entire populations in return for any deaths of Chinggis Khan's family members and associates in the course of the sieges.[59] Nevertheless, there are still surprisingly few indications of architecture newly built in the second half of the twelfth century.

By contrast, evidence of the re*occupation* and re*purposing* of various sites throughout the Bamiyan basin *has* survived the effects of time. Based on the study of ceramic assemblages from several of the latter sites, their reoccupation has been principally dated to the later twelfth-century Shansabani command of the region.[60] The excavations at Shahr-i Zuhak (Figures 3.9 and 3.10), along with surface surveys of the nearby hilltop complexes of Sarkhushak (Figure 3.23), and recent excavations at Shahr-i Ghulghula (Figure 3.12) and in the core Bamiyan valleys, can be considered together with the documentation of numerous historical remains on the routes of passage to the west of Bamiyan (Figures 3.14–3.18). As it stands, the available evidence seems to indicate a shifting Shansabani presence in the region, quite plausibly mapping onto their consolidation of control over the valley and its surroundings, and adapting to the defensive needs of these newly acquired territories (see below). As we know, Bamiyan ultimately served as the seat of a collateral and competing Shansabani lineage, achieving variable success *vis-à-vis* its Firuzkuhi cousins.

Archaeological explorations of the Hindu Kush brought to light at least ten advantageously perched complexes along Bamiyan's western access routes (Figures 3.14–3.18).[61] Further documentation and – ideally – excavation at least at some of these sites would be required for beginning